

A Hex on the Evil Eye

Dabbling in voodoo and reciting magical incantations may not help all that much towards protecting your PC. To be really effective, here's what you need

Intrusion has many forms. You may have the latest and best security systems, or a fierce guard dog to keep your home safe. But some forms of intrusion go unnoticed in spite of all the hi-tech security gadgetry. Take for instance all that valuable data that you have stored on your desktop PC. Is it safe from people who can use your PC for pushing pirated software and illicit activities such as hacking? Is your credit card account information and all those intimate e-mails safe from prying eyes? Here are a few simple steps to ensure that your computer is not broken into.

While these steps will not make your system completely intruder proof, they will help towards keeping most Peeping Toms from accessing your machine without your permission.

Talismans for Windows

Boot passwords are a somewhat effective, albeit low-level method of security. However, boot passwords can be over-ridden by resetting jumpers or removing the CMOS battery. Another simple security measure you can implement is to have a password protected screensaver. But bear in mind that getting past the screensaver password is as simple as restarting the PC! A more secure method is to use a 'Windows Lock', which requires a user ID and password to access a PC.

Windows NT, 2000 and XP have inbuilt Windows Locks and user management, which can be used to restrict access to your PC. You need to provide a username and password to gain access. However, it's a different story with Windows 95/98. Security was not a highly

rated issue when Microsoft designed these operating systems. Nevertheless, System Policy Editor (Poedit.exe) is a tool included with Windows 9x that helps you set user access and privileges. You can install it from your Windows 95/98 installation CD by going to **Settings > Add/Remove Programs**. Click on the 'Windows Setup' tab and then on 'Have Disk'. Browse to `admin\apptools\poedit` in Windows 95, or to `reskit\netadmin\poedit` in Windows 98, for accessing the poedit.inf or grouppol.inf files (depending on your Windows version) and install the System Policy Editor. Restart your PC and set the user privileges you would like to assign to other users.

System Security 2001 is a handy utility, which helps you set access and permission criteria for users on your PC. It also helps you lock up your desktop at startup and when you are not around. System policies can be set in System Security 2001, which help you allocate access rights for each user. This means separate passwords and accounts for users, varying levels of protection, etc.

Encryption and decryption

So now that you have your passwords, user accounts, and all those Windows Locks in place, you probably think that your confidential data is finally safe, right? Well, think again! The truth is that anyone can take your hard disk out, plug it into another PC and access your information.

The way out of this dilemma is to encrypt your sensitive data. Encryption basically converts your data into a secret code. To convert it back into the original

PHOTOGRAPH: Jiten Gandhi, IMAGING: Neeta Wadiker



Keep out Prying Eyes

Set up a BIOS password to stop unwanted guests from getting past the bootup screen. You can set the boot password through your PC's BIOS. Press [Delete], [F1] or [Esc] to enter your BIOS during startup.